

The circadian rhythm

The circadian rhythm is a hormone cycle responsible for creating feelings of wakefulness and sleepiness in humans. It's linked to the body's level of melatonin, a hormone produced by the brain, and also influenced by exposure to light. When the sun goes down, the brain raises melatonin levels, causing tiredness. When it's light again, melatonin levels fall, prompting a person to wake up.

The differences between a teen's rhythm and an adult's help to explain why many teens struggle to wake up early. Teen brains start releasing melatonin later than adult brains do, around two to three hours later, meaning they feel don't feel tired until late in the evening. Furthermore, a teen's brain continues to produce melatonin for about three hours after an adult's, meaning that waking up for school can often feel like waking up in the middle of the night.

GOOD TO KNOW

Insomnia

Having difficulty falling or staying asleep is known as insomnia. People who have insomnia often wake up feeling unrefreshed, find it hard to nap even when they feel tired, and are often unable to concentrate in the daytime. Insomnia can be caused by a multitude of things, including anxiety and stress, other health conditions, lifestyle factors, or bad sleeping habits.

Avoiding caffeinated drinks for a few hours before going bed and limiting the use of electronic devices in the evening might help, but it's worth seeing a doctor if insomnia persists.

▼ Bad habits

Poor-quality or too little sleep affects mood and makes it harder to concentrate, in addition to increasing the risk of long-term health problems.

